replacements for a growing fishing industry based on slavery—and, in turn, they are profiting from the fishing boats that function using slave labour.

Aftermath

By mid-June 2015 the worst of the crisis seemed to be over. Indonesia and Malaysia were allowing those at sea to land and Myanmar had effectively closed its borders. This, at least, avoided the risk of mass death at sea when the monsoon brought bad weather back to the Andaman Sea. But it did not offer any real solutions, and all the signs are that the ongoing persecution of the Rohingyas will continue to have major effects in the region.

Myanmar is clearly conflicted, unsure whether to force the Rohingyas out—a stance that has drawn US censure in the past—or to keep them in what are effectively concentration camps in the country. Since it has no intention of allowing the Rohingyas to live normal lives, it is hard not to see this as tantamount to slow murder—a kind of genocide by attrition. However, what 2015 has revealed is the linkage between the refugee outflow from Myanmar, people trafficking and other regional states, especially Thailand, which have allowed slave labour to become an important part of their economic system. As noted, slaves are now so cheap their lives have almost no value, even to the slave owners.

Of course, beyond the regional powers, there is yet another instance where other governments have opted to turn a blind eye. Abbot's statement about 'reckless' refugees sits badly with reports of individuals being forced onto the boats. Equally, the global food companies share some responsibility: they buy the products of the regional fishing industry and are clearly turning a blind eye to the conditions of the workers.[114] In effect, persecution in Myanmar now feeds people into an economic system largely based on slave labour, which would collapse if the refugees were no longer desperate to escape.

To add to the misery, some refugees who had escaped the country tried to return to Myanmar, fearing being trapped at sea in the monsoon season.[115] They had sold all their assets to pay for their escape and were left destitute when forced to return to Rakhine. In some cases, those who had stayed in the camps paid the smugglers to release those trapped on the ships. It is likely that each period of relative calm in the Andaman Sea will be marked by a refugee outflow. However, each year those trying to escape